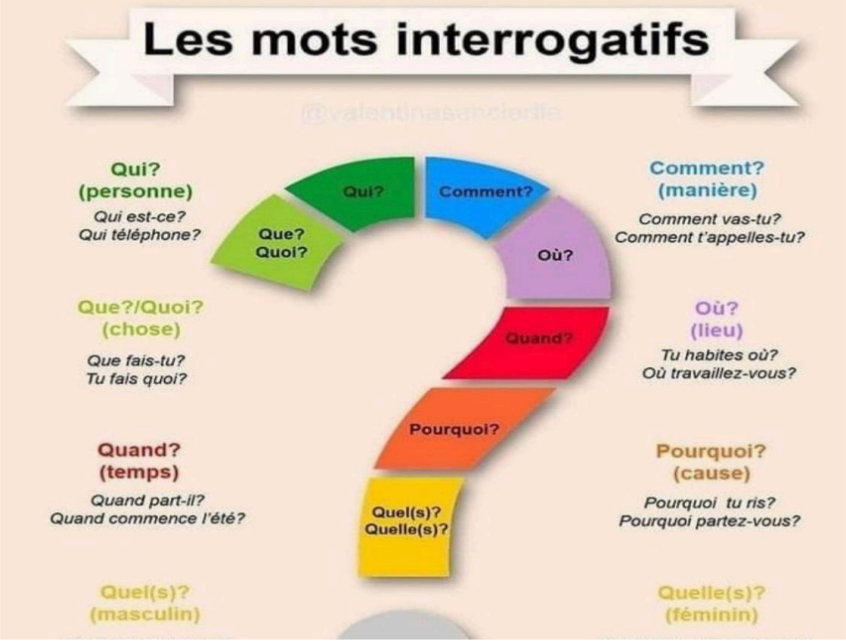
Interrogative Sentences

How to ask questions in French



Intonation (Informal)

In this, we just create a simple indicative sentence, but raise the tone at the end to make it sound like a question. This is an informal way of asking questions.

Français	English
Tu as mon livre ?	Do you have my book ?
Vous avez votre passeport ?	Do you have your passport ?
Elle porte un masque ?	Is she wearing a mask ?

An affirmative response to an affirmative interrogative sentence takes **oui** (Yes).

Français	English
Ils vont au travail ? - **Oui,** mais plus tard !	Are they going to work ? - Yes, but later !
Vous avez de l'argent ? - **Oui,** un peu.	Do you have money ? - Yes, a little.

On the other hand, an affirmative / positive response to a negative interrogative sentence takes **Si** (Yes).

Français	English
Ils ne vont pas au concert ? - **Si**, mais plus tard !	Are they not going to the concert ? - Yes, but later !
Vous n'avez pas d'argent ? - **Si**, un peu.	Don't you have money ? - Yes, a little.

Est-ce que (Slightly More Formal / Colloquial)

It is commonly used in Spoken French. One should avoid using it in a formal situation.

Français	English
Est-ce qu'il va nous accompagner ?	Is he going to come with us?
Est-ce que tu es prêt ?	Are you ready ?
Est-ce qu'elle ne va pas se marier ?	Is she not going to get married?

Inversion (Formal)

This is the most formal way of asking questions in French.

Français	English
Puis-je vous aider ?	May I help you?
Pouvez-vous répéter, s'il vous plaît ?	Can you please repeat?
Parlez-vous français ?	Do you speak French?

Note: When the verb 'pouvoir' is conjugated in the first-person singular i.e., **je peux,** it becomes **puis-je** in inversion.

Furthermore, if the third-person singular of a verb ends with a vowel, **'t'** is added to facilitate pronunciation.

Français	English
Elle parle russe. Parl**e-t-elle** russe ?	She speaks Russian. Does she speak Russian?
Elle a de la fièvre ? **A-t-elle** de la fièvre ?	She has a fever. Does she have a fever?
Il chante bien.	He sings well.

Chant**e-t-il** bien ?	Does he sing well?

Inversion : When the subject is a Noun

Français	English
Les femmes viennent du Japon. Les femmes **viennent-elles** du Japon ?	The women are from Japan. Are the women from Japan?
Sophie va au Canada. Sophie **va-t-elle** au Canada ?	Sophie is going to Canada. Is Sophie going to Canada?
Kaustubh habite en France. Kaustubh **habite-t-il** en France ?	Kaustubh lives in France. Does Kaustubh live in France?

Tag Questions

Certain tag expressions are added, such as **n'est-ce pas; non** and **pas vrai** at the end of an indicative sentence to make it a question.

Français	English
Il joue bien au tennis, **n'est-ce pas ?**	He plays tennis well, doesn't he?
Nous faisons une bonne équipe, **n'est-ce pas ?**	We make a good team, don't we?
Ma sœur chante bien, **non ?**	My sister sings well, doesn't she?
Elle est française, **pas vrai ?**	She is French, isn't she?

Note - The tags don't change irrespective of the tense of the sentence.